

RELIGION

Journal of the KSR

Vol. 28

No.

3

August

1991

The **Major World Religion that Vanished: Gnostic Manichaeism**

by

Paul Allan Mirecki

Early History of
Manichaeism

"You will not die, for God knows
that when

you
eat of

the tree of the knowledge
of good and evil] **your eyes** will be
opened and
you will be like God, knowing good
and

evil.

**

Genesis

3 : 4-5

The Religion of Light,
now referred to as Manichaeism,
was one of the major world
religions and the **only such** religion
to grow out of late antiquity's Near
Eastern gnostic religious tradition.
Originally considered by scholars to
be a Christian **heresy**, Man-
ichacism is now properly
understood in the context of
third-century Mesopotamian ori-
ental religions. **It** was founded by
the Iranian prophet Mani (216-77),
who **created a** uni- versal
propagandistic religion from a mix
of Christian, Zoroastrian, and
Buddhist prac. tices and
concepts. **The** religion moved **east**

toward India and west into the Roman Empire already in Mani's lifetime, reaching as far west as Algiers and southern Europe and as far east as Central Asia and southeast coastal China where traces of the religion datable to the early seventeenth century can be identified.

Mani was born on 14 April 216 in Mesopotamia (modern Iraq) and his parents were of Persian descent. His mother, called Maryam was of royal descent, while his father, Patik, was a devotee in a Jewish-Christian

baptismal sect with gnostic beliefs and ascetic practices. Mani entered the baptismal

sect at the age of four, but received a revelation at the age of twelve when an angel called "The Twin" appeared to him and ordered him to leave the baptismal sect at an unspecified later date. The crucial second revelation came at the age of twenty-four when the angel ordered him to begin his public ministry by preaching the newly revealed doctrine. His "new teaching" (Mark 1:17) put Mani at odds with the traditional community and he was forced to leave with the support of his father and only two faithful followers. The primary point of contention was probably his typical gnostic argument that baptism was useless and that true redemption only comes from the physical and moral separation of light from darkness, spirit from matter, and good from evil. Mani

proclaimed himself the Apostle of Light (1 Corinthians 9:1), the Paraclete Incarnate whose coming was prophesied by Jesus (John 14:16, 26), and the Seal of the Prophets who would bring the final revelation to all the world. He viewed all previous religious traditions as contaminations of the originally true teachings of the earlier prophets Buddha, Jesus, and Zoroaster. He proclaimed instead the final revelation, the true universal religion which would unite all people through his teaching.

His grand plan required propagandistic methods designed to overcome the language barriers which ultimately prevented the revelations of earlier prophets from reaching the universal audience. Mani emphasized the need for the translation of his writings into all languages in order to propagate his teaching as effectively and quickly as possible. In

direct contrast to earlier true prophets (like Jesus), whose teachings were put into written form by their followers (like Mark) who then contaminated those teachings with their own interpretations, he himself produced seven "canonical" sacred writings: (1) *The Living Gospel*, (2) *The Treasure of Life*, (3) *The Pragmateia*, (4) *The Book of Mysteries*, (5) *The Book of the Giants*, (6) *The Letters*, and (7) *The Psalms and Prayers*. None of these texts is known to survive today in a complete form. Perhaps Mani's most effective propagandistic tool was his ability to instill in his followers a sense of the absolute necessity for an extreme ascetic lifestyle

characterized by the propagation of the religion.

Mani's first mission was eastward, like that of the legendary apostle Thomas before him, and he met an early success in what is now southeast Iran (ca. 240-42). He continued to meet successes when he met with the Persian emperor Shapur I and was granted the freedom to propagate the Religion of Light throughout the empire. Although Mani enjoyed imperial favor, the Magian clergy (cf. Matthew 2:1-11) of the official Persian state religion Zoroastrianism grew intent on persecuting him. The Zoroastrian high priest, strengthened by widespread nationalistic aspirations, was successful in convincing the new emperor to begin official persecution of the movement, and Mani was quickly arrested, interrogated under torture for one month, and died a martyr's death in prison in about the year 277.

Mani's Theology and its Ethical Implications

"If the eye could see the demons that people e universe, existence would be impossible" Talmud,

Berakhot, 6

Mani's teaching embraced an elaborate historical drama of supracosmic proportions in which humanity's past origin, present predicament, and future possibilities are described. The drama centers its theological concern on the existential question of the origin of evil in human experience. Mani employed a

typical apocalyptic scheme in which cosmic history was divided **into** three time periods: the past, the present, and the future. In the past there existed two eternal principles, one all good and the other all evil. The good principle exists exclusively within the Kingdom of Light and finds its focus in the **Father of Greatness** whose throne is surrounded by 156 peace-loving spirit-beings in five peaceful "dwellings" (intelligence, knowledge, reason, thought, and deliberation). The evil principle and the Kingdom of Darkness are the complete antitheses of the good principle and the Kingdom of Light. The many inhabitants of the Kingdom of Darkness are controlled by five evil rulers who are in constant opposition to each other and who, collectively, make up the hellish "Prince of Darkness." They are controlled by unreined passions and dwell in an ominous nether-world of smoke, fire, wind, water, and darkness. The two kingdoms are completely distinct yet eternally coexistent.

monstrous

The present period of human existence begins when the evil inhabitants of the Kingdom of Darkness drive a wedge into the Kingdom of Light in a lustful desire to possess it. The Kingdom of Darkness is thoroughly aroused and its vicious inhabitants enter the light in a full-scale invasion. The rest of the drama in the present

time focuses on the work of the Father of Great- **ness to** regain each and every **one** of the precious light particles swallowed by the evil rulers. He **causes** the creation of an elaborate cosmic mechanism (visible in **the** sky **at** night) to distill the light from the **matter**. This "cosmic distillery" **is** the Column of Glory (our Milky Way) which transports the recovered light particles (the visible stars) to the Moon-ship (one can observe it filling up over the course of a month!) and then **to** the Sun-ship which transports the light particles to their temporary haven (the New Earth; cf. Revelation 21:1).

The Prince of Darkness, in an attempt to prevent the cosmic distillation of light particles, gives birth to two evil demons who in turn give birth to exact miniature replicas of the confused light-matter" macrocosm: Adam and Eve (Genesis 1:27). In a typically nnostic inverted reading" of Genesis 1-5 (an orthodox rabbi's nightmare!), the evil creator of the Genesis **story** only creates

matter (which for the gnostic Manichaeans, is inherently evil) and is unable by his very nature to **create** in the manner of the Father of Greatness by evoking pure spiritual beings. Consequently, Adam (representing humanity) **is** specifically designed by the evil creator "in his own image" to **procreate sexually** (Genesis 1:26-28). **Thus**, Adam **can** only continue the evil cycle of birth, copulation, and rebirth and in so doing fulfills his natural **evil**

inclination (representing **human sexu-** ality) to be "fruitful and multiply" (Genesis) 1:28), and so entangles more **precious light** particles in potentially endless generations of human bodies (representing the mistake known **as** human history). But since Adam was ignorant of the light within him and the facts of his true origin in the Kingdom of Light, the evocations of the Father of Great- ness send the redemptive "Jesus of Light" to awaken Adam, to lead him to the self- recognition **of his** true nature and his true origin in **the** Kingdom of Light (Genesis) 3:1-22). Jesus of Light helps Adam eat of the Tree of Life (thus Adam receives the knowl- edge of good and evil), warns him of the dangers of sexual procreation with Eve, and **so** encourages an ascetic lifestyle (absolutely central for Manichaeism ethics). Then Eve, through an evil male angel, gives birth to Cain who then copulates with his mother Eve who gives birth to Abel (Genesis 4:1-2), and so begins the incestuous interaction of Cain **and** Abel with Eve and with **each** other's daughters borne by Eve (Genesis 4:2-17; Cain's wife was thus his sister- daughter). Eve then receives magical knowl- edge from **an** evil angel which would enable **her** to copulate with the **ascetic** Adam. She succeeds **in** her desire with Adam and **bears** Seth who, **as** the first **true** son of Adam (Genesis 4:25a, 5:3, 4b), contains a **signifi-** cantly **larger** amount of **light** particles than the

other offspring of Eve. The ascetic Adam and Seth become the exemplary human **figures** in Manichaeism (Genesis 4:26b; 5: 1-32; Luke 3:38) since, like all human beings, they are self-conscious particles of light entrapped in innately evil material bodies.

The future time is the third and final act of the historical cosmic drama and provides for Manichaeism a preview into the system of rewards and punishments. The Great War will break out among the unenlightened powers of darkness when the distillation of light particles from the material cosmos has neared its completion. Jesus will return at a decisive eschatological moment as the Great King and will judge humanity and the infernal powers. The Elect will become angels, the Auditors will be judged righteous, and the sinners will be cast into hell with Eve and her hellish offspring. The remaining light particles will be gathered and finally return by ascent to the Kingdom of Light while the Prince of Darkness and his diabolical minions will be cast into a bottomless pit permanently sealed with a huge stone for all eternity. The two principles of Light and

Darkness will again be two separate and distinct **entities**, but never again to co-mingle..

Manichaeism Church and
Ethics

"Having come from the light and
from the
god
s,

here **I am** in exile, separated from them" A fragmentary Manichaean manuscript (Tur-

fan

M7)

Individual human beings **are** replicant microcosms of the confused "light-matter" macrocosm. As such they endure an eternal struggle within their own souls for release from matter and return to their true home in the immaterial Kingdom of Light. After the ignorant individual human soul **has** been awakened (**and** thus becomes knowledgable **or** "gnostic"), that individual is conscious of the eternal dualistic realities which control its fate and so can only now hope to succeed against influences from **the** lower physical **nature**. This internal struggle **was** described by Mani in Pauline **terms concerning the** "New Man" **and** "Old Man" who **are** locked in mortal combat (I Corinthians 3:9-10; Ephesians 4:22-24). The individual **can** **succeed** in this struggle through the protection of angelic guides who are accessible only in **the** teaching of Mani and the guidance **of** the Manichaean church. Strict adherence to the extreme ascetic requirements are impossible to enforce on the

popular level and, **were** they to **succeed**, would result in the eventual extinction of the human race. Knowing that such commitment could only be expected **from** himself and a few choice believers, Mani divided his church into two basic classes, the Elect and the Auditors.

The Elect **are** required to keep **the** "Five Commandments" (to be pure and poor and not to lie, kill, or eat flesh) and **to** avoid evil speech and **the** drinking of alcohol. The vegetarian requirement was imperative **for** the Elect **since**

plants **contain** more light particles **than** flesh. The light particles **are** digested through the bodies of the vegetarian. Elect, released through their belches into the **atmosphere**, distilled by the cosmos, and finally sent on their homeward journey along the Milky Way to the Kingdom of Light. Orthodox Christian heresiologists thus ridiculed Manichaeans Elect as "saviours of god"! The Elect were barred from any activity which might injure material objects containing light particles. Thus planting, harvesting, or even walking over the smallest plants could prevent the liberation of the light particles they contain. Since the procuring and preparation of vegetable foodstuffs often required the destruction of light-bearing plants, the elect were not permitted to their own meals, and instead were prepared served by the Auditors who were pardoned

"

for the unavoidable destruction of plants. Even bathing was not allowed for the Elect since pure water (an element from the Kingdom of Light) could be defiled by contact with material bodily substances! The Elect also avoided sexual intercourse since the process of birth, copulation, and rebirth was directly related to Adam's lower material nature, as human sexuality was invented by

the evil creator **to** enslave light **particles** in material bodies. Only the Elect would return to the Kingdom of Light directly **after** death, while the light particles **or** souls **of the** Auditors could only hope **to enter** into the bodies of light-bearing vegetables after death. and finally **be** freed through the digestive systems of the Elect! All humans who are not awakened will **be forever** damned into **an** inescapable cycle of reincarnation in the bodies of animals like lizards and frogs culminating in their permanent entrapment in the Kingdom of Darkness.

A History of Manichaeism after
Mani's Death

"A stranger in this world, I've got a
home
on
high,
in another land so far
away,

in another time, in
another place" Van
Morrison, Astral Weeks
(1967)

The history of Manichaeism **after**
Mani's death **is** extremely complex
due to its twelve- undred year
development along a **continu-**
ous geographical spectrum
embracing west- ern North **Africa**
and southern Europe on its western
edge and coastal south- east China
on its eastern edge. The present
essay **traces** only the general
contours of that geo- historical
development.

The intense heresiological
polemic **against** Manichaeism

resulted in a now only partially extant literary corpus reflecting the westward movement of the religion. Orthodox Christian theologians like Titus of Bostra (d. 371), Ephraim of Syria (d. 373), Cyril of Jerusalem (d. 386), John Chrysostom (ca. 390), and Epiphanius of Salamis (d. 403) all preached and wrote vehemently against the Religion of Light. In Egypt, Serapion of Thmuis wrote a lengthy refutation against the Manichaeans (ca. 339) and at about the same time the neo-Platonist and former Manichaean Alexander of

Lycopolis rejected the naïve literalism of Manichaean cosmology, as Augustine was to do several decades later.

In North Africa, Augustine's (354-430) nine-year association with the religion and later polemical writings against Manichaean doctrine and practice are the most famous evidences of Manichaean presence in North Africa. Augustine was himself a Manichaean auditor for nine years while keeping teaching posts in Tagaste and Carthage. His advanced studies in rhetoric led him to the philosophical analysis of logical problems

"The fear of subversive political infiltration from Persia set the Roman authorities on guard against Manichaeans."

which ultimately resulted in his gradual abandonment of the naïve Manichaean solution to the problem of evil in human experience. Augustine made a lateral move into Christianity under the influence of Christian intellectuals

like Bishop Ambrose of Milan. Augustine's "Anti-Manichaean Penta- teuch" included five anti-Manichaean trac- **tates** written **before** his ordination **in** 391. After his ordination he continued his pol- **emic** against Manichaeans until at **least** 399 with **ten** more polemical tractates dealing exclusively with Manichaeism.

Imperial policies against the Manichaeans **are clear** evidence of the religion's presence in Rome itself, greater Italy, and throughout the empire. The emperors Diocletian (302), Valentinian I (372), Theodosius I (**381**), Theodosius II (408-50), Anastasius I (491-518), Justin I (518-527), and Justinian (529) **all** sought to control the spread of the religion. The fear of subversive political infiltration from **Persia set** the Roman au- **thorities on** guard against Manichaeans. **Pope** Leo I (ca. 444-45) delivered **sermons. meant** to inform the faithful of the Man- ichaeian threat, **and** even circulated a pas- **toral** letter to the Italian bishops urging them to be aware of Manichaean infiltrations in the orthodox clergy!

Manichaeism travelled eastward **across** Persia into Central **Asia** already in **Mani's lifetime** through his missionaries who fol- **lowed** the silk **routes** eastward **and intro-** duced the religion to China in **the** seventh century (650-83). The first Chinese imperial edict against Manichaeism (732) **was meant** to limit the spread of the religion among Chinese nationals. It calls the religion a

perverse belief masquerading **as** a school of Buddhism intending to mislead the **common** people. The religion **spread** through the Yangtze Basin where four Manichaeian temples **were** built in 768 and contacts with Chinese nationals were allowed. But the Chinese populace **grew** more intolerant against foreign culture **as** the **T'ang** government began to legislate contacts between foreigners and the Chinese people. The government found itself relatively free of foreign influence when the neighboring Uighur empire collapsed in 840. It closed Manichaeian temples with an imperial **letter** of **843** resulting in **a** most unfortunate massacre of Manichaeians. Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, and

Nestorian Christianity also fell out of imperial favor **as** nationalistic Confucian influence now predominated at the imperial court.

A fifty-three year period of political chaos (907-960) followed the fall of the T'ang Dynasty in 907 and provided Manichaeian missionaries with the opportunity to **propagate** the religion in the coastal regions of south-east China. Buddhist historians of the Sung Dynasty (960-1280) blamed the chaos of the earlier period and even contemporary social problems on Manichaeians who had by then successfully **integrated** themselves into Chinese society. The Sinicisation of the Religion of Light (Ming-chiao), involved the establishment of Manichaeian temples under the guise of Taoist temples. This resulted in one of the

most significant early victories for Chinese Manichaeans: the inclusion of a major Chinese Manichaean text into the official canon of Taoist scriptures compiled under the **reigning** emperor between 998 and 1022. The text thus received imperial protection during the official confiscations of foreign texts in the early 1120s. Many such groups were called by the derogatory name "vegetarian demon worshippers" and were subject to blanket prosecution and harassment. The government blamed five rebellions between 1130 and 1150 on "vegetarian demon worshippers" and issued twenty edicts against such groups between 1132 and 1209.

China reopened its borders to foreign influence during the eighty-eight year period of Mongol rule (1280-1368). The Silk Road was reactivated and the **seas** between the south China coast and the Persian Gulf **were** busy with trade ships. The Mongol policy of religious toleration **allowed** Manichaean missionaries to continue their work without official harassment. Even Marco Polo seems to have encountered a group of Manichaeans he thought **were** Christians! The Mongol control of China began to erode with the death of Kublai Khan in 1294. **A series** of uncoordinated rebellions began in south China and increased to the point that one of the rebel leaders **recaptured** Peking **from** the Mongols in 1368 and established his Dynasty of Light (Ming-chao). Several **sects**

were proscribed by his edict of 1370 including **the** Religion of Light (Ming-chiao).

The rest of our knowledge of the Religion of Light in China concerns the Manichaeian **temple on** Hua-piao Hill in Ch'üan-chou, Fukien province. An inscription on **the temple's statue** of Mani dates the statue to 1339. Historical references, preserved in the writings of Ho Ch'iao-yüan (ca. 1600) suggest **that** the southern Chinese Manichaeians in Ch'üan-chou **were** still considered a distinct social group at the beginning of the seventeenth **century**. But Chinese scholars of the Ch'ing Dynasty (1644-1912) had **no** exact knowledge of the identity and nature of the Religion of Light.

3

Afterthought

"**And** God saw everything that he had **made**, **and** behold, it **was** very good"

*genesis

1:31

What we observe **in** the checkered history **of** Manichaeism **is** **the rejection, and** in too many **cases** the annihilation, **of a minority** religious **group** which struggled **against** **a**ll odds to find **a** home within several **cultures** **over** a twelve-**hundred** year period. To **read** the accounts of professional orthodox **heresy-**hunters like Augustine is to **read** the story of **a** nefarious devil-**inspired** religious move-**ment** intent on damning **human** souls to hell. To **read** actual Manichaeian texts (pick **any** one, the

Psalmbook for example) is to read the story of **an** intensely pious, harmless, and quiet people who wanted only to **experience** God (which they recognized as the same God Jesus worshipped) and to help the plight of a suffering humanity by their unique combination of **an** ascetic **lifestyle** and **a** radical critique of **the status** quo. The orthodox heresiological tradition, whether Christian, Muslim, or Confucian, may have been justified in its attacks on the naïve **literalism** of Mani's cosmology and his simple solution to **the** problem of evil in human existence. No

doubt the Manichaeans, like Jews and Christians in various times throughout **their** histories, **were** challenging the commonly **accepted** interpretation of human reality which just did not work for them, and in so **doing presented** **themselves as** a political threat (**an eastern** "Persian **threat**" to Rome, a **western** "**barbarian**" threat to China). **The** destruction of the Manichaean religion, the only major world religion to grow out of late antiquity's Near Eastern gnostic religious tradition, has resulted in the **destruction of a** human natural resource, a voice that offered a viable alternate perspective on human existence.

Mani's negative evaluation of human existence, that the physical creation was a mistake of an inferior minor god, was certainly in sharp contrast to orthodox Christian and **Jewish** belief that human existence in this world is positive and

meaningful (**Genesis** 1:10 "And God saw that it **was good**"). This clash of mythologi- cal structures, of opposing and irreconcilable world-views, led ultimately to the destruc- tion not of those who were essentially in error, but of those who were without political power, and who were perhaps too convinced for their own **good** of the absolute "truth" of their own religious beliefs.

Paul Allan Mirecki is Assistant Professor of Religious Studies, with interests in the areas *of* New Testament Studies, Hellenistic liter ature, the Roman World, **and** Gnosticism. He received his **B.A.** from Roosevelt Uni- versity, **his** M.A. from Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary, and his Th.D. *in* New Testament and Christian Origins from Harvard University **in** 1986.